Ive Botunac_

AI Research Engineer · Assistant Professor · PhD in AI
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Zadar, Croatia · Updated October 2026



AI research engineer, assistant professor and founder. I build agentic AI systems, lead partnerships, and publish – from LLM-driven trading systems to a mental-health app with 1.5 million+ downloads.

18+	10+	10	40
years in software development	years in AI	published papers	course certificates

01 ABOUT

AI researcher and engineer with more than 18 years in software development, over ten of them in AI. I help companies adopt AI from strategy to implementation: preparing organizations, building agentic AI systems, and teaching teams to work with AI. My background combines entrepreneurship, leadership and research. I founded and ran my own ventures, led AI and R&D teams, and work on European defence projects with partners across Europe. Today I lead partnerships at ALFATEC Group and CroAI, contribute to national AI policy, and teach computer science as an assistant professor.

02 EXPERIENCE

ALFATEC Group
2020 – now · 5 yrs 11 mos
Full-time · Zagreb, Croatia

Director of Partnerships — Jul 2025 – Present
Lead strategic partnerships and acquisitions – partner relations and AI coordination across international consortia on European Defence Fund projects such as HYBRID and LODESTAR II.

Director of Research & Development — Dec 2021 – Aug 2025
Drove the application of AI across innovative solutions – leading projects, collaborating with global partners, and building product teams.

Data Scientist — Dec 2020 – Nov 2021
Built machine-learning solutions tailored to client needs and helped form a team dedicated to in-house products.

University of Zadar
2026 – now · 4 mos
Part-time · Zadar, Croatia

Assistant Professor — Jul 2026 – Present
Teaching computer science at the new Department of Mechatronics and Robotics and helping build its study programme.

CroAI – Croatian AI Association
2024 – now · 1 yr 11 mos
Nonprofit · Zagreb, Croatia

Board President — Dec 2025 – Present
Leading CroAI into its next chapter – new statute, Management & Supervisory Boards, and the direction of Croatia's AI community.

Vice President (acting President) — Dec 2024 – Dec 2025
Shaped Croatia's AI ecosystem – 3,600+ educators trained through "AI se educiraj", and a seat in the working group for Croatia's AI Strategy 2026–2032.

04 SKILLS

AI AGENTS & LLM APPS
LangGraph · LangChain · MCP · Claude Code · OpenAI · Gemini · Anthropic · AWS Bedrock AgentCore · ChromaDB · AssemblyAI

ML RESEARCH
PyTorch · Stable-Baselines3 · Transformers · PEFT · Unsloth · TRL · Optuna · scikit-learn · pandas · TensorFlow · Backtrader

MOBILE
Ionic Vue · Capacitor · RevenueCat · Swift · ARKit · LiDAR

WEB
Nuxt · Vue · TypeScript · Pinia · Tailwind · React · Redux Toolkit · TanStack

BACKEND & CLOUD
Node.js · Firebase · Google Cloud · AWS · Express · DynamoDB · SQS · CDK · PostgreSQL · Redis · Docker

ENGINEERING
Vitest · Playwright · GitHub Actions · Jest · Cypress · MLOps

05 EDUCATION

PhD, Informatics
University of Rijeka, Faculty of Informatics and Digital Technologies · 2017 – 2025
An Automated Stock Market Trading System Based on Deep Reinforcement Learning

MSc, Management
University of Zadar, Department of Economics · 2015 – 2017
Applying machine learning methods to predict the movement of the stock market index

BSc, Nautical Studies & Maritime Transport Technology
University of Zadar, Maritime Department · 2012 – 2015
Evolution of the cyber threat in the maritime industry

Primo Technology Ltd. — 2025 – now (1 yr 9 mos)
Self-employed · Zadar, Croatia

Founder — Feb 2025 – Present
My AI consulting agency and indie dev studio – strategy, implementation and training, plus my own AI-powered mobile and web products.

Sintelly — 2017 – 2025 (8 yrs 8 mos)
Full-time · Zadar, Croatia

Founder & CEO — May 2017 – Dec 2025
Founded and led Sintelly, an AI + CBT mental-health app that reached over 1.5M downloads.

Zadar Developers Hub · ZadarConnect — 2022 – 2025 (2 yrs 10 mos)
Zadar, Croatia

President — Sep 2022 – Jun 2025
Led the ZadarConnect project – meetups and the SheepAI Hackathon (88 participants, €35,000 prize pool), growing Zadar's tech community.

Ministry of Defence (MORH) / Croatian Air Force — 2009 – 2017 (8 yrs 1 mo)
Zadar, Croatia

Technician — Feb 2009 – Feb 2017

03 PUBLICATIONS

2025 **Automated Trading Framework Using LLM Driven Features and Deep Reinforcement Learning**
Ive Botunac, Tomislav Petković, Jurica Bosna

2025 **Implementation of a Multi-Agent AI System for Financial Trading Decision Making**
Ive Botunac · *Oeconomica Jadertina*

2024 **Comparing Fine-Tuning and Prompt Engineering for Multi-Class Classification in Hospitality Review Analysis**
Ive Botunac, Marija Brkić Bakarić, Maja Matetić · *Applied Sciences (CC)*

2024 **Opportunities of Gen AI in the Banking Industry with regards to the AI Act, GDPR, Data Act and DORA**
Ive Botunac, Natalija Parlov, Jurica Bosna · *13th Mediterranean Conference on Embedded Computing (MECO), SCOPUS*

2024 **Optimization of Traditional Stock Market Strategies Using the LSTM Hybrid Approach**
Ive Botunac, Jurica Bosna, Maja Matetić · *Information 15.3 (2024): 136, SCI index* · doi.org/10.3390/info15030136

2024 **Artificial Intelligence, ESG Innovations in Tourism, and Personal Data Management**
Natalija Parlov, Nada Bašić, **Ive Botunac** · *Acta Economica Et Turistica*

2020 **The Effect of Feature Selection on the Performance of LSTM Neural Networks in Stock Market Predictions**
Ive Botunac, Ante Panjkota, Maja Matetić · *31st DAAAM International Symposium, SCOPUS*

2019 **The Importance of Time Series Data Filtering for Predicting Stock Market Movement Using Neural Networks**
Ive Botunac, Ante Panjkota, Maja Matetić · *30th DAAAM International Symposium, SCOPUS*

2017 **Analysis of the Security Challenge in Maritime Cloud Computing**
Ive Botunac, Juraj Poljak, Dino Županović · *7th International Maritime Science Conference, Split (TRID)*

2017 **Analysis of Software Threats to the Automatic Identification System**
Ive Botunac, Marijan Gržan · *Brodogradnja 68(1): 97–105, SCI index*

06 CERTIFICATIONS

2025 Agentic AI
DeepLearning.AI · Course

2023 Generative AI with Large Language Models
Coursera · Course

2023 Machine Learning Specialization
Coursera · 3 courses

2022 Product Owner Training (Certified Product Owner)
Product Manager HQ · Training

2022 Natural Language Processing Specialization
Coursera · 4 courses

2021 Reinforcement Learning Specialization
Coursera · 4 courses

2021 Data Engineering, Big Data & ML on GCP
Coursera · 5 courses

2021 Google Cloud: Cloud Data Engineer (prep)
Coursera · 6 courses

2019 DeepLearning.AI TensorFlow Developer
Coursera · 4 courses

2019 Advanced Machine Learning on Google Cloud
Coursera · 5 courses

2018 Machine Learning on Google Cloud
Coursera · 5 courses

2018 Deep Learning Specialization
Coursera · 5 courses

2016 Machine Learning
Coursera · Course